
Teacher Primer

Teacher Support

Hackles · a free kit · quillsup.org · October 2026

Hackles Teacher Support Pack, Document 1 of 5. Read time: about 6 minutes. No tech background needed.

Hackles · Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell. Hackles · a free kit · quillsup.org. © 2026 Competence Collective. Lesson text and teaching materials: CC BY-NC 4.0 (free to print, share and adapt for non-commercial use with credit). The Hackles name, logos, characters and artwork are not covered by that license: print and share them unaltered for classroom and family use; any other use needs written permission. [VERIFY with counsel]

You do not have to be a tech expert

YOU AREN'T BEING ASKED to know every app, and it wouldn't help if you did, because apps change every year. What helps kids stays the same: a calm adult, a clear routine, and the message that **telling someone is always okay**. If you can listen, stay steady and know who to call, you can teach this curriculum well.

The one routine: Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell.

EVERY LESSON IN THE kit comes back to one noticing step and three action steps. Learn them yourself, because a routine you've practiced on your own is one you'll reach for without thinking when a child is standing at your desk looking worried.

STEP	IN KID WORDS	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Hackles up?	"Something feels off. Uh-oh."	Noticing the feeling: too good to be true, pushy, secret, or scary. Hand brushed up the back of the neck.
Pause	"Stop. Breathe. Don't answer yet."	Not clicking, not replying, not paying, not sending.
Check	"Is this real? Who is this, really?"	Does it feel rushed or secret? Does it ask for a password, a picture, or money? Could a grown-up I trust help me check?
Tell	"I'll tell a trusted person."	A parent or caregiver, teacher, counselor, coach, or a helpline. Telling is never tattling and never getting in trouble.

A false alarm is fine and welcome, and if a child's hackles were ignored, or they were tricked anyway, it is never their fault. They tell someone.

What is Hackles?

YOUR HACKLES ARE WHAT rise on the back of your neck when something feels off. The program teaches children to **notice that feeling and act on it**: Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell. Hackle is the friendly baby-hedgehog mascot whose pale-yellow, tangerine-tipped quills stand up when something is wrong. Hackle appears in the K-5 materials, and only as a small corner icon in grades 6-12. "Trust your hackles" does not mean "you must always be right." A false alarm is welcome, and a child who was tricked anyway is never at fault. No student accounts, no student data collected, ever.

What kids actually run into

YOU DON'T NEED THE details of every risk. You need to know the main kinds, so that you recognize them when a child mentions one. In plain language:

- **Scams and tricks.** A message or pop-up that promises free game money or a prize, or pretends to be a company or a family member. The giveaway is pressure. "Hurry." "Secret." "Give me your password."
- **Taken-over accounts.** Someone gets into a child's game or social account, often through a fake login page, and uses it to trick their friends or spend money.
- **Unkind behavior online.** Mean group chats, embarrassing pictures posted, someone left out, screenshots passed around. It follows kids home, because their phones go home with them.
- **Pressure from someone they met online.** Someone friendly in a game gets more and more interested, asks to move to a private app, asks for secrets or pictures. It can be an adult pretending to be a kid. Often it's a stranger. Sometimes it's someone the child half-knows.
- **Threats after a picture is shared (sometimes called sextortion).** Someone says they'll share a private picture unless the child sends money or more pictures. The picture may be real, or it may be a fake made with AI. Every part of this is the fault of the person making the threat, never the child.
- **Fake pictures and voices made with AI.** Tools can make a picture, video or voice that looks real. Some get used to embarrass or threaten classmates, and some copy a family member's voice for a scam call.

- **Chatbots that act like friends.** AI companions can feel caring, but they are not a person, they can be wrong, and they don't replace a trusted adult.

Statistics on how common these are change fast. If you quote numbers to families, take the current figure from the organization that publishes it (for example NCMEC or the FBI), and check it first.

Four facts to keep in mind

1. **Most kids are not in trouble.** Most children use technology safely most of the time. We're building skills, and fear has no part in it.
2. **Shame is the biggest obstacle.** Children often stay silent because they believe they'll be blamed, punished, or lose their device, so the way you react to a small "oops" tells them whether it's safe to bring you a big one.
3. **Anyone can be targeted.** Smart, careful, popular and shy kids all have been. Never suggest a child "should have known better."
4. **Early telling gives the most options.** Mean message or threat, it makes no difference. The sooner a trusted adult knows, the more can be done.

What to say, what not to say

HELPFUL	NOT HELPFUL
"Thank you for telling me."	"Why did you do that?"
"This is not your fault."	"You should have known better."
"You are not in trouble."	"I'm going to have to take your phone."
"I'm glad you came to me. Here is what we can do next."	"Let's keep this between us." (You cannot promise secrecy.)
"Tell me more about what happened." (open question)	Detailed who, what, why questioning (leave investigating to others).

If a child tells you something serious

IF A STUDENT DISCLOSES

Short version (full steps are in the Disclosure and Incident Guide):

- Stay calm. Find a private moment, but keep the child visible to other adults if you are alone.
- Listen. Believe. Say "Thank you for telling me. It's not your fault."
- Do not promise secrecy. Say you must tell people whose job is to help.
- Do not view, copy, forward or screenshot any intimate image. Do not ask the child to show it to you.
- Report personally and promptly, as your state law and your school policy require. Telling the principal may not be enough. [VERIFY with your district policy]
- Write down the child's own words, the date and time, and who you told.

Your role is recognition and response

YOU ARE NOT EXPECTED to investigate, confront anyone, play therapist, or solve it alone. Your job is to **notice, listen, reassure, report, and hand off** to the people trained to take it from there, and the curriculum teaches students the same two moves: recognize it, then respond by telling.

Before you teach a lesson

- Know your counselor's name and how to reach them today. Tell them the lesson topic and date. Some lessons (grooming patterns, sextortion, fake images that hurt) are more likely to prompt disclosures.
- Know your school's reporting steps. Keep the one-page protocol where you can find it in a hurry, which means not in a drawer.
- Send the family pre-notice letter for sensitive lessons (templates are in the Family Engagement Pack; see also the Counselor Heads-Up and Opt-Out Toolkit).
- Plan a calm closing routine: a stretch, a breath, a reminder of the trusted adults in the room.
- Look after yourself. These topics can stir up your own experiences. The Disclosure and Incident Guide has a self-care section.

Words kids use (a short decoder)

WORD	MEANING
Group chat	A shared conversation among several people in a messaging app.
DM	Direct message, a private one-to-one conversation.
Screenshot	A picture of what is on a screen. It can be used to keep proof, and also to spread something.
Block / report	Block stops contact. Report tells the app to review the account or content.
Handle / username	A name used online. It may not be the person's real name.
AI chatbot	A program that writes replies like a person.
Deepfake	A fake picture, video or voice made to look real.
Two-step verification	A second check, such as a code, when logging in. It protects an account even if the password is stolen.

Where to get help (confirm local numbers with your school) [VERIFY]

- Your school counselor, administrator, and school safety contact.
- Your state child abuse hotline or local child protective services (CPS) and local law enforcement.
- NCMEC CyberTipline: report.cybertip.org or 1-800-843-5678 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: report.cybertip.org].
- 988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline (call or text 988) for immediate emotional crisis [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: official sites of the named services].

This primer is educational guidance, not legal advice. Consult your district policy and counsel on reporting duties in your state.